



THE FIGHT FOR AMERICA'S FAMILIES

Exposing the Corruption in Family Courts and CPS.

They took my kids. They tried to silence me. They WON'T.

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 24

MINNESOTA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Minnesota's family courts and child-welfare system.

44

MINNESOTA FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
76 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 13 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 1, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

22 OF 87

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MINNESOTA AT A GLANCE.

Across 44 Minnesota families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 76 44 of 44 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$12,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 13 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 54.5% 34.1% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 44	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.7	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 44 of 44	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 22

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Minnesota families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MINNESOTA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	26	\$12,000	\$48,281	\$1,255,300
Lost Wages	24	\$16,000	\$82,833	\$1,988,000
Other Court Fees	21	\$1,200	\$17,888	\$375,654
Therapy / Evaluations	20	\$500	\$2,525	\$50,500
Reunification Services	19	\$100	\$9,008	\$171,150
GAL Fees	20	\$350	\$2,040	\$40,809
Asset Loss ¹	27	\$20,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$50,150	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$20,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		13	1.1 yrs
Mean months lost		38	3.2 yrs
Total across all families		1,131	94.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · MINNESOTA

Most families documenting in Minnesota are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		18	41%
Active case: stuck or delayed		14	32%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		6	14%
Case closed: within last 2 years		3	7%
Not in court but still affected		2	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		17	39%
Family Court Only		14	32%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		9	20%
Unknown		4	9%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		10	23%
3 – 5 years		9	20%
Over 10 years		8	18%
5 – 10 years		6	14%
6 months – 1 year		4	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		12	27%
Visitation Only		10	23%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		7	16%
50/50 Joint		6	14%
Full Custody		5	11%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Crow Wing		2	5%
Scott		2	5%
Stearns		2	5%
Koochiching		1	2%
Hennepin		1	2%
Dakota		1	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		12	27%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		9	20%
Other: (Short answer)		9	20%
High Conflict Divorce		4	9%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		3	7%

05 PARENT VOICES — MINNESOTA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Minnesota comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Covered up abuse and silenced my kids and myself. Has not protected my son he lives with the step sister that molested him full time now!

— MELISSA

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

It all started when the county did abatement on my property an discriminate an used slang words against my kids an me for no reason at all an for things that where not even true in the front page of the newspaper then are house burnt down they came an took are kids for no reason [...]

— MINNESOTA PARENT · NICOLE

MORE VOICES FROM MINNESOTA

It has destroyed my children trust in there's someone to help. Caused unimaginable stress that affects day today normal things..

— ANGELA

It's broken me and I can only imagine the pain my children are in

— CAITLIN

Destroyed my family, killed one of my children, has separated all four of my children in two different housing placements

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They attempted to silence and assassinate me, my children, my faith and used my belief in God to persecute me and eventually traffick my daughter Lillian.

— KATHRYN

My kids were taken because my oldest wanted to make false claims against me because he wanted to live with his dad. And he got caught with porn on his phone and having not so nice messages with other children and my son got my other so to say things that where not true because he [...]

— AMANDA

Placed my children into a transvestite sex ring . Of physical abuse ignored by a friend group very powerful in my town

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Ripped child from home and 2 siblings, extended family and child has no rights. Loss of finance's, freedom and business income, added stree and trauma to all.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They broke my family apart and never had no intentions of reniting us back together. I had 2 sets of twins and they stole my children.

— MOLLIE

This has traumatized and stolen our life from us. So many missed opportunities to be a normal person like everyone else, all because of a system that cycles families through a system that doesn't even work and leaves you financially broken and too stressed out to think straight.

— BUFFY

Ripped us apart as a family and perpetuated abuse that was already failed to be addressed. I've said the damage is already done and it's true; but will not be in vain.

— STEPHANIE

I have 7 more children in SD since my case in mn which proves my case is the strongest and easiest case to win if I had a lawyer. Same county that stole my son had prior paid me as unlicensed daycare provider for my sister's kids. I have enough to file federal lawsuit and 3 [...]

— ROBIN

Severely damaged my three children and their mental health, damaged my children's relationship and bond with me, and my family, financially destroyed me, causing significant debt.

— DONNA

They have robbed me and my family of a normal family and they are still doing it to this day

— DUSTIN

This poor excuse of a family justice system costed me my life, literally. My daughter and son are my life and the very reason I breathe, but because of a bias referee and myself not being very knowledgeable when it came to representing myself in family court, I was literally [...]

— TAMARA

Destroyed lives of people & property financial exploitation REVICTINIZATION Not to the BEST INTEREST THEY LIE

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My children were removed and court decisions were made before I was ever properly served or given notice, and I have been trying to participate in a process that moved forward without me. I initially intended to represent myself but was forced to request a court-appointed [...]

— ALICIA

Harassed, tormented and Traumatized and it's still continuing for over 5 years after I beat them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Minnesota court system has failed way me and keep me from my children. After they where moved out of state for 2 years

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Lost my oldest son last 3 years of his life now that he is 19 he was taken away from me when he was 16 3 most important precious years of his life without due process no court hearings no nothing all because of carlton county here in cloquet minnesota one cps worker that made it [...]

— TISHINA

Steve Shermone private attorney / city attorney /retired and Judge Jerrod Shermone's brother relationship created a conflict of interest in your case, and that an improperly handled ex parte motion contributed to a broader pattern of judicial bias and procedural violations. The [...]

— AMBER

It is literally destroyed me. It is me and my kids super sad some moaning talk to me now because they think I wasn't there when I was the guy I tried make it seem like I didn't love my kids or something, but all I wanted was my kids they've turned me into a person that. Didn't [...]

— BRADLEY

I lost my job because of them I feel lost without them family is very upset

— BRITTANY

The family court system has handed my children to a documented abuser and Cluster B individual putting our children in harms way. This monster has a porn addiction intertwined with drugs and violence. My children are not safe with him- their emotional health, physical health [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Disparaged and put in danger

— ALICIA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Taken valuable time and moments that we will never get back and they drove a wedge between us. They do everything they could do divide and separate us when they were supposed to be reunifying our family

— TESSA

Made my life complete hell. I'm amazed I'm still alive

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Made us hate each other more than we did before the divorce

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Caused major physical harm to my daughter, and made sure we couldn't live on our own for years. Sucked us financially dry...

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The family court system has profited from not only ripping my family apart; the one I gave up my career to build, but protecting the one who threw everything I build in the garbage, and continued to profit over allowing him to perpetuate neurological battery that has developed [...]

— SARA J

I can't change the cards I was dealt. I can only change the way I play the game. God always provides my team. A pawn can take out the King. The system tried to break us while God built us..

— JOCELYN

I made sure to have professionals backing up my claims thinking it would be a quick case. Because he has money he has been able to draw it out which is not in the best interest of the child. Courts don't care. It's just about the money.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

33 Minnesota parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 33 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MINNESOTA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Minnesota families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Covered up abuse and silenced my kids and myself. Has not protected my son he lives with the step sister that molested him full time now!

— MELISSA

It all started when the county did abatement on my property an discriminate an used slang words against my kids an me for no reason at all an for things that where not even true in the front page of the newspaper then are house burnt down they came an took are kids for no reason at all then when we bought a new house the health department went out to my property that I still own an they took all my brand new stuff from my property witch they had no reason to even be on my property or take my stuff an collapse my septic tank I should have been able to leave my stuff there being I own the property then a couple months after after i bought a new house the law enforcement came to my door with a sherch warrant an took all my guns an stuff from me for no reason at all me an my other half have nothing on are back rounds for them to do that an they still won't give us them back we are not criminals an just recently they made both of us apply for are permittes to purchase guns an they denied both of us an said that they took are gun rights away because of supposedly a pending felony but we have no open cases on either one of use an we are also still fighting to get 2 of my kids back from CPS taking them for no leight reason but yet I still have full custody of my oldest child 5 months after we had lost are whole life to a traffic house fire then the county went after me an my other half for fraud an my oldest child saying he didn't live with me when all 5 of us had not a place to live we where all homeless after the fire so where staying at hotels for 3 months strait an my oldest didn't like staying at the hotels so he would go stay at my parents house off an on with should have

— NICOLE (1/3)

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

never been a problem at all they are family an at the time being we where all homeless till we could get the insurance claim for are house figured out so we could all move forward with are family life together as we did before the fire so they sent the fraud case to a different county an in the end I won that whole case but have never seen anything back of the things the took from me an my family expecalkt when time was hard anyhow with lossing everything already an still to this day they just keep going at us for no reason at all we do nothing wrong an we hardly ever leave are house but yet the cops are sitting everywhere around are house all the time or following use around the harassment from the cops are getting old when all me an my family want in life is to be a family together an just start are new journey together after losing everything to a house fire but we just can't witch has really messed with me an my whole family's mental health for absolutely no reason at all an I have been trying to get me an my family's life tragedy story out there so my I could get someone to help us get back together as a family I have even tried reach out to lawyer to get help with all the eleagle things that have now been done to my family but can't find anyone to even give us any time in the day for nothing and I even have all the proof on all the things that have never been done to us for no reason at all but can't get no one to hear are sides of any of the things they have done to my family physical an emotional they have tookin everything away from my family an we now have NOTHING an can't even be that family that we had an we deserve cause we are human an no different from

— NICOLE (2/3)

anyone else here in this world we live we don't deserve the torcher the harassment the mental health problems so please if anyone has any good advice for us or could help us in any way would be very grateful appreciated. An help to us so we could move forward in life as the family we where before we lost everything to a house fire let us know please an thank you an God bless you.

— NICOLE (3/3)

It has destroyed my childrens trust in there's someone to help. Caused unimaginable stress that affects day today normal things..

— ANGELA

It's broken me and I can only imagine the pain my children are in

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06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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My kids were taken because my oldest wanted to make false claims against me because he wanted to live with his dad. And he got caught with porn on his phone and having not so nice messages with other children and my son got my other so to say things that were not true because he threatened him. And they keep saying the kids will come back and they are not

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Placed my children into a transvestite sex ring . Of physical abuse ignored by a friend group very powerful in my town

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I have 7 more children in SD since my case in mn which proves my case is the strongest and easiest case to win if I had a lawyer. Same county that stole my son had prior paid me as unlicensed daycare provider for my sister's kids. I have enough to file federal lawsuit and 3 civil lawsuits against alexandria, mn. The same county I have documented proof of all they did wrong against me as a child then to my one son they stole. CPS only steals, kills and destroys lives just like satan does.

— ROBIN

Severely damaged my three children and their mental health, damaged my children's relationship and bond with me, and my family, financially destroyed me, causing significant debt.

— DONNA

They have robbed me and my family of a normal family and they are still doing it to this day

— DUSTIN

This poor excuse of a family justice system costed me my life, literally. My daughter and son are my life and the very reason I breathe, but because of a bias referee and myself not being very knowledgeable when it came to representing myself in family court, I was literally prayed upon. I thought the truth would set me free and I jumped through every hoop I was asked to and not asked to do and I proved everything my exhusband was alleging against me as false and still I lost my kids not all at once, it started little by little and eventually nothing.

— TAMARA

Destroyed lives of people & property financial exploitation REVICTINIZATION Not to the BEST INTEREST THEY LIE

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

My children were removed and court decisions were made before I was ever properly served or given notice, and I have been trying to participate in a process that moved forward without me. I initially intended to represent myself but was forced to request a court-appointed attorney after being denied the opportunity to present objections, or evidence or be heard.

— ALICIA

Harassed, tormented and Traumatized and it's still continuing for over 5 years after I beat them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Minnesota court system has failed way me and keep me from my children. After they were moved out of state for 2 years

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Lost my oldest son last 3 years of his life now that he is 19 he was taken away from me when he was 16 3 most important precious years of his life without due process no court hearings no nothing all because of carlton county here in cloquet minnesota one cps worker that made it happen name Raija Haag and her supervisor Samantha hill made it happen I lost my oldest daughter this year she was 15 years old by another cps worker name jana hoglum here in cloquet minnesota also by Carlton county it definitely has made an impact on me and my family it has been a hard journey lots of years and heartbreak our family hasn't been the same since 2022 there were several cases that the county had filed against me we finally had all my children together for Thanksgiving this year and Christmas cause my family helped with that including my mom but our family were grieving for the last couple of years due to the cases that were open it has definitely impacted my relationships with them and it's hard for my older ones to reach out to me I have lots to explain to you wish I had more time to talk to you about everything that has happened to my family and my children due to cps here in cloquet minnesota (Carlton county)

— TISHINA

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Steve Shermone private attorney / city attorney /retired and Judge Jerrod Shermone's brother relationship created a conflict of interest in your case, and that an improperly handled ex parte motion contributed to a broader pattern of judicial bias and procedural violations. The family relationship was not disclosed or properly screened for conflict under judicial ethics standards. - Decisions affecting your case were made in a context where impartiality could reasonably be questioned due to the familial connection. - You believe an ex parte motion was filed or processed improperly, without your knowledge or opportunity to respond, and that this action materially harmed your case. - These events contributed to a pattern of procedural irregularities, lack of transparency, and decisions that appeared to favor individuals connected to the Shermone family network.

— AMBER

It is literally destroyed me. It is me and my kids super sad some moaning talk to me now because they think I wasn't there when I was the guy I tried make it seem like I didn't love my kids or something, but all I wanted was my kids they've turned me into a person that. Didn't care about nothing after they cut my kids and I want my life back. I deserve my kids back.

— BRADLEY

I lost my job because of them I feel lost without them family is very upset

— BRITTANY

The family court system has handed my children to a documented abuser and Cluster B individual putting our children in harms way. This monster has a porn addiction intertwined with drugs and violence. My children are not safe with him- their emotional health, physical health, and education has all been affected. He continues to withhold my children despite the 3 court orders allowing me video calls with my children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Disparaged and put in danger

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06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Taken valuable time and moments that we will never get back and they drove a wedge between us. They do everything they could do divide and separate us when they were supposed to be reunifying our family

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The family court system has profited from not only ripping my family apart; the one I gave up my career to build, but protecting the one who threw everything I build in the garbage, and continued to profit over allowing him to perpetuate neurological battery that has developed severe nervous system dysregulation. The epitome of corruption.

— SARA J

I can't change the cards I was dealt. I can only change the way I play the game. God always provides my team. A pawn can take out the King. The system tried to break us while God built us..

— JOCELYN

I made sure to have professionals backing up my claims thinking it would be a quick case. Because he has money he has been able to draw it out which is not in the best interest of the child. Courts don't care. It's just about the money.

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33 full approved Minnesota comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Minnesota report comes from Minnesota respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Minnesota — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 44 Minnesota families reporting here are not the universe of Minnesota families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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